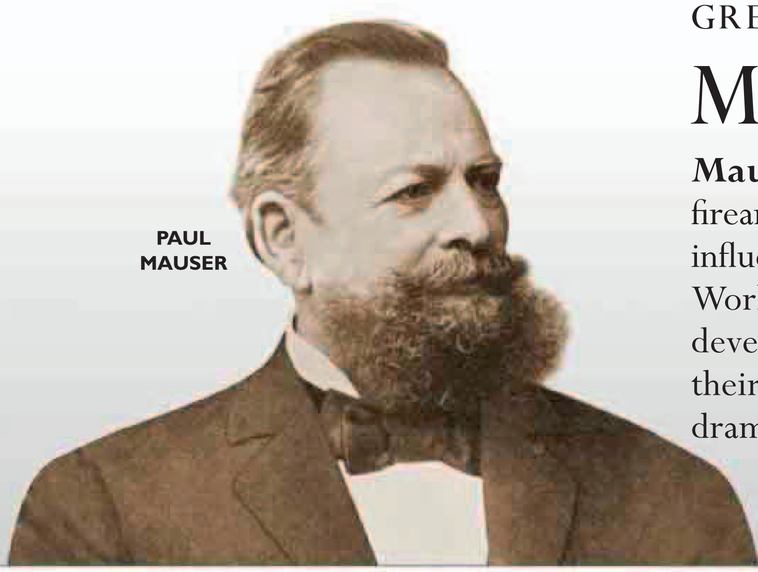

PAUL MAUSER

GREAT GUNSMITHS

MAUSER

Mauser is one of the most celebrated names in the history of firearms design. Although Paul Mauser, its creator, died in 1914, Mauser's influence was still clear in the design of many of the rifles in use during World War II. It was in the late 1800s and early 1900s that Paul Mauser developed a series of bolt-action rifles, weapons that became known for their ease of use and reliability. This helped them sell in large numbers, dramatically changing the way battles were fought.

Paul Mauser was born into a family of German gunsmiths and his father, Franz Andreas Mauser, worked at the Württemberg Royal Armory. Paul Mauser was drafted as an artilleryman in 1859 and did his military service at the arsenal at Ludwigsburg. Here, he was able to continue his trade as a gunsmith. At both the Royal Armory and at Ludwigsburg, the young Mauser found that the prevailing rifle was the Dreyse needle-fire rifle (see pp.108–09), a bolt-action weapon. Although the Dreyse rifle was widely used, Mauser wanted to improve it, in particular to eliminate problems such as gas blowback (caused by expanding gases created by the ignition of the propellant) and the gun's tendency to discharge accidentally. So from the 1860s onward, Mauser began to develop new bolt-action weapons to address these issues.

▲ **MODEL 1898**
German troops used this rifle very effectively in World War I. It replaced the Model 1888 rifle as the main rifle in service in Germany.

"The **pistol** was the best thing in the world."

WINSTON CHURCHILL, FORMER PRIME MINISTER OF UK, **ON THE MAUSER C.96**

TRANSFORMING WARFARE

Bolt-action rifles began to become popular in the 1860s and Mauser patented his first one in 1868. The advantages of the bolt action for loading a gun at the breech were immediately clear—it was reliable and easy to use, and because it did not have a downward-moving lever it could be fired and loaded more easily in a prone position than a lever-action rifle. Also, unlike muzzle-loading guns, it did not have to be loaded while standing up, making it safer to use in battle. Bolt-action weapons would gradually become more widespread. Mauser's weapons also used metallic cartridges. This overcame a major problem with the Dreyse needle-fire rifle, with its long, needlelike firing pin, which sometimes caused the weapon's paper cartridges to discharge accidentally when the bolt was being closed. However, all early Mausers were single-shot weapons and were at a marked disadvantage compared to the repeating rifles introduced by Winchester in 1866. Mauser began to design bolt-action rifles with a repeating action in which a cycle of the bolt loads the chamber for the next shot. The most successful of these was the Model 1898 (see p.153), which took five smokeless cartridges in a disposable charger (or stripper clip). Light and easy to use, the Model 1898 was one of the most successful rifles of its time, a reliable repeater that could be loaded and fired from a prone position and could stop an enemy advance in its tracks. Adopted by the German Army (where it was given the designation Gewehr 98), the rifle played a major part in World War I and set a high standard for other manufacturers to emulate.

◀ **GERMAN TROOPS WITH MAUSER RIFLES**
Seen here is a group of German troops in battle, in about 1916, aiming their Mauser Gewehr 98 rifles from a ruined building.